

Phrase 甲骨文

甲骨文

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Everyday example: Think about the last time you counted something — apples in a bowl, steps to the door, coins in your pocket. The very first count is always *one*. Before two, before ten, before a million, there is one.

Picture this: The Chinese character 一 (pronounced *yī*) is as simple as it looks: a single horizontal stroke, like a line drawn with one confident sweep of a brush. It means *one* — the number, the unit, the beginning. Nothing in written Chinese is simpler. That is its beauty.

Simple rule: 一 represents the number 1 and carries a deeper idea too: *wholeness* and *unity*. When something is described as 一, it is complete in itself — undivided. In the phrase 马到成功 (*mǎ dào chéng gōng*, "success upon the horse's arrival"), the spirit of 一 lives underneath: commit as *one*, with single-minded focus, and success follows instantly.

Try it yourself: Write 一 now — just one slow, left-to-right horizontal line. Say *yī* aloud as you do. Notice how the stroke and the sound together feel complete. Then count three objects near you: *yī, èr, sān* (one, two, three). You have just spoken your first Chinese numbers, and 一 — the simplest stroke of all — was your starting point.

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Everyday example. Think about a tall, straight fence post planted firmly in the ground — it stands upright, confident, and unmoving. That single vertical line is exactly what you are looking at in the stroke 丨.

Picture this. In Chinese writing, every character is built from a small set of basic brushstrokes, much like how every house is built from a handful of shapes — walls, roofs, windows. The stroke 丨 (pronounced *shù*, meaning "vertical") is one of the most fundamental of all. It is a single, clean downward line, drawn from top to bottom in one smooth motion.

Simple rule. Whenever you write 丨, your brush or pen starts at the top and travels straight down. Think of it as drawing a 1 on a piece of paper, but without the little foot or hat — just the bare vertical line itself. Formally, you can think of it as a line segment along the *y*-axis: moving in the direction $(0, -1)$ from start to end.

Try it yourself. Grab a pencil and draw five vertical lines, one after another, each about the same height. Try to keep them parallel and equally spaced. Notice how the simple act of drawing that single straight line already feels deliberate and intentional — that sense of purpose is exactly the spirit of 丨, the backbone hidden inside countless Chinese characters you will soon recognize.

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Everyday example. Think of the way water slides off a slanted roof — it flows smoothly from upper-right down to lower-left, then simply lifts away without a hook or pause. That natural, effortless sweep is exactly what the stroke 丿 feels like when you write it.

Picture this. Imagine you are drawing a single blade of grass bending in the wind. You place your pen near the top-right, glide diagonally downward toward the lower-left, and lift your pen off the page at the end. No stopping, no curling, just a clean, confident sweep. That is 丿 — called *piě* in Chinese, which roughly means "to throw aside." The stroke literally tosses itself off the page.

Simple rule. 丿 always travels from **upper-right** → **lower-left** and ends by lifting the pen cleanly. You can remember it as the "slash" stroke. It appears in dozens of everyday characters — look closely at 人 (person), 入 (enter), and even in 兔 (rabbit), one of the characters in the phrase 守株待兔 that we are exploring in this book.

Try it yourself. On a piece of paper, draw five 丿 strokes in a row, each one starting a little further right than the last, like a row of falling raindrops. Try to keep each stroke smooth and light at the end. Once this feels natural, you have mastered one of the most common building blocks in written Chinese — a small skill with enormous reach.

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Everyday example. Imagine sweeping crumbs off a table with one smooth motion of your hand — starting gently at the top left, gliding down and to the right, then pressing a little heavier just before you lift your fingers. That single, satisfying sweep is the spirit of the stroke ㄣ.

Picture this. In Chinese calligraphy, every character is built from a small set of basic strokes, the way all words in English are built from just 26 letters. The stroke ㄣ is called the *nà* (捺) stroke. It travels diagonally from the upper-left down toward the lower-right, gradually widening and pressing into the paper, then ending with a crisp, flat tip — like a bird's wing opening as it lands.

Simple rule. Whenever you see ㄣ inside a character, you know that character carries this rightward, sweeping energy. The stroke goes: light start → smooth diagonal descent → heavier press → clean lift. You can think of its path as a gentle slope: $y = -x$ shifted to end with weight.

Try it yourself. Trace the air in front of you with one finger. Begin near your left shoulder, sweep diagonally down to the right, slow down as you near the end, press slightly, then lift cleanly. Did it feel like one flowing motion? That is exactly right. ㄣ teaches you that power in Chinese writing often comes from *how* a stroke ends, not just where it begins.

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Imagine you are counting on your fingers. You start with one hand, then two — and when all ten fingers are up, you spread your palms wide in a satisfying cross shape. That moment of *completeness* is exactly what the character 十 (shí) captures.

Picture this: draw one horizontal line across the page, like a calm horizon. Now draw one vertical line straight through its center, like a pillar reaching up and down. What you have is a perfect cross — and that is 十, the character for *ten*.

The simple rule is this: 十 is always written in exactly two strokes, in a fixed order. First the horizontal stroke (left to right), then the vertical stroke (top to bottom). In Chinese, stroke order matters — it keeps the character balanced and beautiful, and it helps your hand build muscle memory.

十 is more than just the number ten, though. In Chinese culture, ten symbolizes *completeness*, the feeling that nothing is missing. When you achieve 马到成功 — instant, full success — you might say you gave 十分 (shí fēn), meaning *ten parts*, or *one hundred percent* of yourself.

Try it yourself: Pick up a pen and write 十 five times, saying *shí* aloud with each stroke. Notice how two simple lines create something whole. You have just written one of the most ancient Chinese characters — and you did it in two strokes. That is already a small victory!

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Think of a fence around a backyard, or the walls of a room keeping everything safely inside. That idea — *a boundary that holds something in* — is exactly what the Chinese character 口 captures.

Picture this. Imagine drawing a simple square with your finger in the air: top line, right side, bottom line, left side — a closed loop. That sketch *is* 口. It is one of the oldest pictographs in Chinese writing, representing an enclosure, a border, or a contained space.

Simple rule. 口 (pronounced roughly *wéi*, rhyming with "way") functions as a **radical** — a building block that appears inside larger characters to hint at their meaning. Whenever you see a character shaped like something *trapped inside a box*, there is a good chance 口 is at work. Characters such as 囚 (prisoner — a person 人 inside an enclosure), 国 (country — jade 玉 inside a border), and 园 (garden — a winding path inside walls) all grow from this one root idea: a space with a clear edge.

Try it yourself. Write 口 slowly: four strokes, no gaps, corners crisp. Now look at the characters 囚, 囿, and 围. Can you spot the 口 hiding inside each one? As you find it, ask yourself: *what is being enclosed here, and why might that matter to the word's meaning?* That small act of noticing is exactly the kind of *thinking while learning* Confucius had in mind.

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Everyday example. Have you ever used scissors to cut paper, watching the two blades cross each other to slice cleanly through? That crossing, cutting motion is captured in a single Chinese character.

Picture this. The character 乂 (pronounced *yì*) looks almost exactly like the letter X — two strokes crossing each other near the middle. One stroke sweeps from the upper-left down to the lower-right; the other rises from the lower-left up to the upper-right. Where they meet, they form a neat intersection point. You can sketch it as two directed paths:

 meets  $\implies$ 

That crossing is 乂.

Simple rule. 乂 is a **pictographic primitive** — a building block whose visual shape echoes its original meaning. Its ancient meaning was *to cut* or *to mow*, like two blades meeting to harvest grass. As a primitive, 乂 does not usually stand alone in modern text, but it hides inside larger characters, quietly contributing its "crossing" energy to their meanings.

Try it yourself. Trace 乂 slowly with your finger: begin the first stroke at the top-left and sweep toward the bottom-right. Then add the second stroke starting at the bottom-left, crossing the first as you sweep upward toward the upper-right. Feel the moment the two paths cross — that is the heart of the character. Once you can spot that X-shape, you will start to notice 乂 tucked inside other characters all around you.

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Everyday example: Imagine you're looking at the top of a tent, a roof, or even just a little hat sitting on someone's head. That small peaked shape — a dot with a line spreading out beneath it — is everywhere once you start noticing it.

Picture this: In Chinese characters, this tiny "hat" shape is called 冫 (pronounced *tóu*, meaning "lid" or "head"). It's not a full character you'd use by itself in conversation — instead, think of it as a **building block**, like a single Lego brick that gets used inside bigger, more complete characters. It looks like a small dot sitting above a short horizontal stroke, almost like a roof capping the top of whatever comes underneath it.

Simple rule: Whenever you see this little "lid" shape sitting on top of a character, you can guess that it's contributing the *idea* of something covering or topping another part — much like a roof tops a house. It commonly appears at the very top of characters such as 京 (capital city) or 亭 (pavilion), always playing the role of "the cap on top."

Try it yourself: Next time you spot a Chinese character, scan the very top first. Ask yourself: "Is there a small dot-and-line shape capping it off?" If so, you've found 冫 — your first building-block friend in this character-recognition journey!

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Have you ever looked down at a farmer's field from an airplane window? You notice neat squares of land, each patch separated from the next by dirt paths or low walls. That orderly grid has been a part of Chinese life for thousands of years — and it gave rise to one of the most satisfying characters to write.

Picture this. Draw a rectangle, then add one horizontal line across the middle and one vertical line down the middle. What do you get? A field divided into four tidy plots, exactly the way ancient Chinese farmers organized their rice paddies. That image *is* the character 田 (tián). It is a **pictograph** — a character whose shape comes directly from drawing the thing it represents.

Simple rule. When you see 田 inside a character, there is often a connection to land, cultivation, or something laid out in an organized grid. The character means *field* or *rice paddy*, and it appears in common words like 田地 (tián dì, farmland) and 稻田 (dào tián, rice field).

Try it yourself. Write 田 slowly in four strokes: outer frame first, then the inner cross. As your pen moves, imagine plotting out rows of seedlings in muddy water. Notice how the structure feels balanced and complete — four equal sections, nothing wasted. That sense of orderly use of space captures the spirit of 田 perfectly.

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Every culture has a moment when marks on a surface stop being decoration and become *meaning*. In Chinese, that moment is captured in a single character: 文 (wén).

Picture the oldest form of this character — it looked like a person with a pattern or tattoo on their chest. That image says it all: a mark that carries a message. Over centuries, 文 grew to cover everything we make with those marks: writing, language, literature, culture, and learning itself.

The simple rule is this: 文 points to *any human-made pattern that communicates*. A painted brushstroke, a line of poetry, the rules of grammar, the customs of a civilization — all fall under the umbrella of 文. Think of it as the word that ties language to culture in one stroke.

You can spot this idea across everyday Chinese words. 文字 (wénzì) means "written characters." 文化 (wénhuà) means "culture" — literally the *transformation* (化) brought by written learning. 文学 (wénxué) means "literature." In the phrase 文房四宝, the "four treasures of the scholar's studio," the 文 at the front tells you immediately that everything in the set belongs to the world of writing and learning.

Try it yourself: look at the character 文 and trace it — one stroke at a time. Then ask: what other English words carry both the meaning of *writing* and *culture* at once? (Hint: think of "text" and "textile" — they share the same Latin root.)

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Everyday example. Think about a school report card. Grades run from A down to F — and "A" means the very best. In Chinese, 甲 (jiǎ) plays exactly that role. Whenever something is ranked number one, first place, or top tier, 甲 is the word for it.

Picture this. The ancient form of 甲 looks like a seed seen from above — a small cross inside a rectangle, as if the seed's first shoot is just breaking out of its shell. That image of *bursting into first* captured the idea of being at the very beginning, the very top. Over thousands of years the strokes simplified, but the meaning stayed: **甲 = first, number one, prime.**

Simple rule. Chinese has a traditional counting system called the *Heavenly Stems* (天干, tiān gān) — ten symbols used to number years, days, and ranks. 甲 is stem #1, just as we might write position 1 in a list. So whenever you see 甲, picture the label on the top slot:

$$\text{甲} = 1^{\text{st}} \text{ (first, top, Grade A)}$$

Try it yourself. Look at the phrase 对牛弹琴. Imagine you had to rank the skill of the audience — a cow listening to music. Would the cow earn 甲 (first place) or something much lower? Thinking about *who deserves 甲* and *who doesn't* is exactly the humor the phrase is poking at. Keep 甲 in mind — it will pop up every time rankings or order appear in Chinese.

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骨

Have you ever built something with LEGO bricks? Each brick has its own shape, and when you click them together, they form something bigger — a car, a house, a dragon. The key insight is that the bricks themselves don't change. Only the combination does.

The concept 骨 (pronounced *gǔ*) works exactly like that. It means "bone" — and just as bones give a body its underlying shape and structure, 骨 represents the *core framework* that holds something together from the inside.

Think of a skeleton: without it, a body would be a shapeless heap. The bones don't do the moving or the thinking — they provide the *armature*, the hidden structure that everything else is built upon.

The simple rule is this: **骨 is the load-bearing inner structure** — the part you can't see on the surface, but which determines the shape of everything above it. When something has strong 骨, it holds its form under pressure. When the 骨 is weak or missing, the whole thing collapses.

In Chinese characters, 骨 appears as a building block inside many other characters related to the body, strength, and physical structure — a tiny skeleton doing invisible work.

Try it yourself: Look at something near you — a chair, an umbrella, a leaf. Can you identify its "骨"? What is the hidden framework that gives it its shape? Naming that inner structure is the first step toward understanding any complex system.

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When you say "birthday cake," you are using two everyday English words together to name one specific thing. Chinese works the same way — characters team up to build richer, more precise meanings than any single character could carry alone. A group of characters that functions as one unit of meaning is called a **phrase** or **compound word**.

Picture three characters standing shoulder to shoulder, each one adding a layer of detail. The first might name a material or setting, the second might highlight a defining feature, and the third might name the broader category. Together they pinpoint exactly one thing in the world. The three-character phrase 甲骨文, for instance, links characters relating to ancient materials with a character meaning "writing," snapping three small pieces into a single, precise label for one historical script.

The simple rule: when you meet a string of Chinese characters that acts as one idea — a name, a term, a concept — read the whole group as a unit rather than one character at a time. Notice how each character narrows the meaning, and the combined sense will often emerge naturally from the parts working together.

Try it yourself: think of a three-word phrase in English, such as "old love song." Each word tightens the picture a little more. The same layering happens in Chinese. Next time you encounter a multi-character term, pause and ask: what does each character contribute, and what precise idea does the whole phrase name?

Payoff

You have spent this entire book learning how Chinese characters work — how pictures became symbols, how symbols gained meaning, and how meaning grows when characters combine. Now you have arrived at a phrase that brings all of that together in three characters: 甲骨文.

Think of the last page of a photo album. Each earlier photograph made sense on its own, but the final page shows the whole story at once. 甲骨文 is that last page.

Each character in this phrase carries its own meaning — shell, bone, writing — and together they name something precise: the oldest surviving form of Chinese writing, scratched onto turtle shells and animal bones more than three thousand years ago. You are not just reading a label; you are reading a description. The ancient scribes who carved those marks were asking questions of the natural world, and the characters they used became the ancestors of every character you have studied here.

Here is the quiet miracle: once you can read 甲骨文 as a phrase, you can recognize it anywhere — in museum exhibits, history books, or a documentary subtitle — and you understand not only what it means but *why* it means it. Shell. Bone. Writing. Three words, one living record of where your language began.

Now pick one character you have met in this book — any one — and ask yourself: what might its earliest carved form have looked like? That curiosity is your invitation to go deeper.